DBQ Point Guide 5: Sourcing Overview (HIPP)

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What the rubric requires

The sourcing point (Row D, 1 pt) goes to an essay that, for at least **two** documents, explains *how or why* a document's historical situation, intended audience, point of view, or purpose is relevant to an argument. This overview ties the four HIPP guides (5A–5D) together.

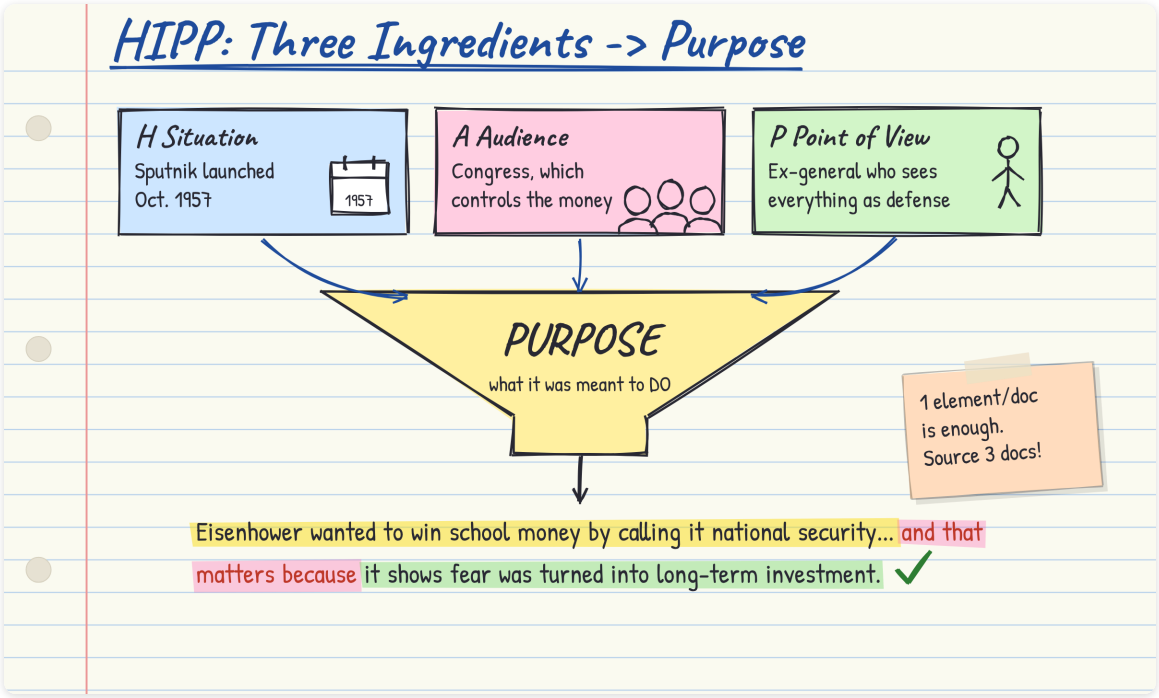
Three rules decide it:

1. **Explain, don't identify.** "Document 3 was photographed during the Cold War" names a situation and earns nothing. The student must say what that situation *shows* for the argument.
2. **Sourcing is not summary.** "Document 1 claims the WPA discriminated against women of color" restates content. Sourcing is about the *source*: who, when, to whom, and why.
3. **Two different documents, each fully done.** One HIPP element per document is enough, but each must be connected to an argument. Sourcing more documents is insurance; four fully sourced documents also earns the complexity point (Guide 6).

The point is all-or-nothing at two documents. 2025 Set 1 Sample 1B earned it with three solid sourcings even though its fourth attempt (Document 6's audience as "the entire government") was rejected as too broad.

Calibration note: 2023 samples were scored when sourcing required **three** documents. The current rubric (DBQ Rubric.pdf) requires two.

How the four parts fit together



The first three usually explain the fourth. A document's purpose rarely comes from nowhere: the author wants something *because* of the moment they're in (H), the people they need to reach (A), and who they are (P). Students who source the H, A, or P and then say "so the purpose was…" are already halfway to a second sourcing and to the complexity point.

Example, Cold War Document G: Sputnik had just gone up (**H**), Eisenhower was speaking to Congress, which controls funding (**A**), and as a former general and president he framed everything as national security (**P**). So his **purpose** was to win emergency federal money for science education by presenting it as defense.

The all-in-one sourcing frame:

> "Because [author / point of view] was [writing / speaking] to [audience] during [historical situation], [his/her] purpose was to [purpose]. This shows [how it supports the thesis]."

The last sentence is the one that earns the point. Without it, everything before is identification.

Pick the easiest element per document. Speeches and letters → audience or purpose. Government documents and court cases → historical situation. Activists, politicians, cartoonists → point of view. Each guide below covers one element in depth.

Essays that earned the point

Source	Docs sourced	What was credited
2025 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7)	3, 4, 5, 7	Audience (Doc 3), historical situation (Docs 4, 5, 7). Four sourced, so it also earned complexity.
2025 Set 1, Sample 1B (score 5)	2, 3, 4	Situation (Docs 2, 3) and purpose (Doc 4: convince lawmakers to support federal healthcare for the elderly). Doc 6 attempt rejected.
2024 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7)	1, 3, 4, 6	One of each: purpose (1), situation (3), audience (4), POV (6).
2024 Set 2, Sample 1A (score 7)	1, 2, 3, 6	All historical situation, each tied to the argument. Shows one element can carry the whole point.
2024 Set 2, Sample 1C (score 3)	2, 6, 7	Situation for all three. Sourcing was earned in a 3-point essay, so it's not reserved for strong writers.
2023 Set 2, Sample 1A (score 7)	2, 3, 4, 5, 7	Mix of audience, situation, and POV. One audience error (Doc 6) was outweighed by five correct ones.

The element-by-element examples are in Guides 5A–5D.

Essays that did not earn the point

Source	What happened
2025 Set 2, Sample 1B (score 4)	Attempted Docs 3 and 5, but “the discussions do not explain how the documents are relevant to an argument.” Identification without connection.
2025 Set 2, Sample 1C (score 2)	Historical situation for Docs 1 and 6 was “too vague.”
2024 Set 1, Sample 1B (score 6)	Tried Doc 2's point of view but “simply repeats information that is specified in the document.” Only one attempt.
2023 Set 1, Sample 1B (score 4)	Said Americans “bragged” about factory life (Doc 6 purpose) without tying it to an argument; no other attempts.
2024 Set 2, Sample 1B (score 5)	Earned 3 of 3 evidence points but never attempted sourcing. Strong evidence doesn't carry over to this row.

Expert tips

Sourcing is one of the hardest skills for most students. It is commonly taught as **HIPP + the "why"**:

- **One element per document is enough.** Pick the one that makes the most sense for that source.
- **The sentence pattern:** "The [historical situation / audience / purpose / point of view] of this document is X, and that matters because…" The second half is the "why" that earns the point. Without it, students are unlikely to earn the point.
- **Source three, not two**, in case a reader rejects one. 2025 Set 1 Sample 1B shows why: its fourth attempt was rejected, and three good ones still carried the point.
- **Source four for complexity** (Guide 6).

Useful lead-ins for placing sourcing right after a document: "The events in this document are situated in the larger context of…, and that's important because…" and "The audience of this document was X, and that suggests…" Element-by-element tips are in 5A–5D.

Grader checklist

For each sourcing attempt, ask:

1. Does it name an H, A, P, or P element of the *source* (not just restate the content)?
2. Is that element accurate and specific (not "the people of America" or "the entire government")?
3. Does the essay say how or why that element matters to an argument about the prompt?

Two different documents with three yeses = 1 point. Four = also flag for complexity.

Feedback stems for students

- Earned: "You sourced Documents [X] and [Y] by explaining how [element] supports your argument that…"
- Identification only: "You identified [element] for Document [X]. Now add: 'This matters because…' and tie it to your thesis."
- Missing: "Pick two documents and use the frame: Because [author] wrote to [audience] during [situation], the purpose was […], which shows […]."

The four element guides:

- 5A Historical Situation: DBQ Sourcing 5A: Historical Situation
- 5B Intended Audience: DBQ Sourcing 5B: Intended Audience
- 5C Point of View: DBQ Sourcing 5C: Point of View
- 5D Purpose: DBQ Sourcing 5D: Purpose